

one here [in Mumbai] only talks numbers."

In the Garden City, Kashyap finds himself recharging his batteries, empowered and enjoying "normal life" where he can walk on the streets and have conversations around cinema, books and daily life. In his own words, he is "busier than Shah Rukh Khan", and loving it. Says Kashyap, "My focus has shifted. I am done fighting for others." It's perhaps in this act of self-preservation that Kashyap hopes to appease his fanboys and, hopefully, win new audiences in the process. ■

—Suhani Singh

OTT ▼

Curtains Pulled Back



ARYAN KHAN steps behind the camera with *The Ba***ds of Bollywood*, his take on nepotism, outsiders and the Hindi film industry's quirks

It's not every day one hears of a Bollywood 'nepo baby' having an off-screen debut. And that's exactly what happens with *The Ba***ds of Bollywood* on Netflix, which marks the writing and directorial debut of Aryan Khan, the eldest son of Shah Rukh Khan. As the title and trailer hint, this one's a less serious and more humorous take on the film industry and its erratic ways. Daddy SRK called it a "sharp and self-aware" show at the teaser launch. Sahher Bambba, who plays a star kid at odds—and eventually in love—with Aasmaan Singh, an outsider and rising star played by Lakshya, calls it "an over-the-top, exaggerated look at what people expect Bollywood to be like".

That's not to say the show didn't resonate with the lead cast of mostly outsiders. Lakshya says there were moments in the script which had happened as he tried to break into the industry. Mostly, though, satire and sarcasm are essential to the drama, says actor Raghav Juyal, who plays Aasmaan's bestie. (The two were having a bloody battle in *Kill* when they were cast for the series.)

For Lakshya, working with Aryan in a show produced by SRK's banner Red Chillies was just one part of the appeal. "I was like, I am like this guy [Aasmaan] only, I will be able to crack this," he says. What he didn't anticipate was its big scale—"*OTT kahaan lag rahaa hai?* [It doesn't look like a show for the small screen]," the length of the project (the shoot went on for over a year) and how passionate Aryan the filmmaker is. "As outsiders, we tend to see people [from the industry] differently, but when you interact, you realise they are like us only," says Lakshya. "There's a childlike innocence to him, and there's warmth for his crew. He is hard-working, hungry and will sacrifice everything to make a good show. He gave up his sleep and ours too and kept us on our toes." Key cast members laughed over how many takes he demanded of them.

It's hardly a surprise that there are cameos galore. The trailer shows the long list, including Salman Khan, Aamir Khan, S.S. Rajamouli, Ranveer Singh and Karan Johar. Raghav says at times he felt he was "in a dream world". While the cast mostly knew when a star would be shooting, Salman's appearance took them by surprise. "He was shooting in the same premises and decided to drop by," says Lakshya. "The set went all crazy." ■

—Suhani Singh

META DRAMA
Lakshya leads a star-studded cast of Netflix's *The Ba***ds of Bollywood*

